How to Ask Mom What She'd Want If She Ever Needed More Help

One unhurried conversation, her answers in her own words, and nothing decided.

You know Mom's opinion on almost everything: the neighbors, the thermostat, the right way to load a dishwasher. What she'd want if she ever needed more help hasn't come up yet.

This guide is for one conversation with one job: hear what she wants and write it down the way she says it. It isn't for deciding anything, and nothing has to change afterward.

Who should be there

Mom, and to begin with perhaps just one of you. Ask her who she'd like in the room. Her answer is one of the things you're hoping to learn.

Brothers and sisters who aren't there can send a question ahead and read the notes afterward. If more than one of you is present, pick one person to take notes. It shouldn't be the person asking the questions.

How to open

Pick an ordinary moment: over coffee, in the car, while the two of you are doing the dishes. Start with a question, not a conclusion.

- “Mom, nothing's wrong. I've just realized I've never asked what you'd want if you ever needed more help around here.”
- “I'd rather hear it from you than guess. Can I ask you a few things, and write down what you say?”
- Say what the conversation is for: hearing what she wants. Say what it isn't for: deciding anything, or changing how she lives now.
- If she'd rather not talk about it today, leave it there and ask whether another day would suit her.

Questions to ask

Ask Mom

1. How do you feel things are going day to day? What's easy, and what takes more out of you than it used to?

2. If you ever needed more help, where would you want to be?

3. How important is staying in this house to you, and what is it about being here that matters most?

4. What would you want from us, and what would you rather we didn't do?

5. Who would you want involved if decisions had to be made?

6. What matters most to you that we should write down?

Ask each other, afterward

1. What did she say that we hadn't known, and did we write it the way she said it?

2. What is each of us able to offer if she asked, and what isn't each of us able to offer?

How to write down what was said

Write her words, not your summary of them. Keep what Mom said separate from what the family thinks, and where she hasn't made up her mind, write that down too. “I don't know yet” is an answer.

WHAT WAS SAID	WHO SAID IT	WHEN	STILL OPEN
“I'm staying in this house. Your father built that porch.”	Mom	Sunday, over coffee	Didn't say what she'd want if the stairs got harder
“I could drive her on Fridays. I can't promise more than that.”	David	On the phone that evening	

What not to decide yet

None of these is today's job. Some are Mom's to decide, and some need a professional who knows her situation. Leave them open. Today is for hearing her.

- Where she will live.
- Whether she needs more help than she has now.
- Anything about her driving.
- Who will do what if things change.
- Anything about money or legal papers.

What you can decide today

- Who will write up the notes, and whether Mom would like to read them.
- Who else in the family gets a copy, with her say-so.
- When you'll pick the conversation up again.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't resolve a disagreement, tell Mom what to choose, or say what a professional will say. It gets her wishes onto paper in her own words, with the open questions left open. Nothing here is medical, legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You've asked Mom what she'd want, and her answers are on paper in her own words. The care interview gives them a place alongside the rest of her situation, area by area, and turns it all into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

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